AFP



THE TRS RIPOSTE
An anti-Modi hoarding in the city

Eatala Rajender, whom KCR sacked from his cabinet and who went on to win a bypoll on a BJP ticket, now heads the saffron party's seven-member panel for poaching. Of these, five joined the BJP barely three years ago. There is not only a coordination committee to pursue prospective entrants, but also one on finances and another to study the gaps in the TRS's governance and the grievances people have. Once identified, the BJP hopes to base its campaign on filling in the vacuum where they see it and make poll promises accordingly.

Simultaneously, the party is strengthening its base at the booth level through several contact programmes. WhatsApp groups of 200 members each have been formed to stay connected. Panna pramukhs, who are in charge of a page of the electoral roll, will remain critical in the party's booth domination strategy—28,000 out of a total of 34,000 have already been appointed. "When grassroots leaders are given a dedicated team of their choice, they feel empowered and take up more responsibilities and can be assigned critical tasks," says Sanjay. They will be essential in the party's grassroots outreach.

Political observers see great merit in this approach ahead of the 2023 assembly election. "The focus is shifting from urban to semi-urban and rural areas," says D. Veerababu of the University of Hyderabad. "The right-wing ideology has had strong roots in Telangana for over three decades. In the electoral history of the BJP, one of its first two MPs, C. Janga Reddy, was elected from Hanamkonda in 1984 (he had defeated the future PM, P.V. Narasimha Rao, becoming the party's first MP in the south). And in 1998, in the erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, the party had 12 MLAs and a vote share of 17 per cent. So, if it reinforces its cadre in rural areas, the BJP has a bright chance."

Holding the incumbent TRS to account is a natural prong in the BJP strategy. "We will pin down the TRS regime by raising 100 questions on KCR's promises by invoking RTI (Right to Information)," says Sanjay. Inter alia, they will trace the assurances KCR gave from June 2, 2014, to June 2, 2022, on his district tours and other meetings, those he gave on the floor of both legislative houses and how many of these have been fulfilled. The BJP also hopes to take KCR to task on his tours to other states by regular or charter flights, whether he stayed at government guest houses or private hotels and the salary he has drawn in the past eight years. The TRS, in turn, plans to turn it into an RTI war to fend off its rival's offensive with some questions of its own. It is countering criticism with vehemence, in the hope of overcoming or at least neutralising anti-incumbency. Its hope of a third consecutive win rests on that. ■



INDIA PICTURE

By Rahul Noronha

The Madhya Pradesh government has adopted a peculiar approach to the economics versus ecology debate in the context of the National Chambal Sanctuary. Conceding that illegal sand mining has been happening in parts of the riverine sanctuary, the government believes that denotifying certain sections to enable the mining to be done legally would help in protecting the rest of the sanctuary. Located at a trijunction of three states—MP, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh—the 435-km-long sanctuary extends 1 km each on both sides from the midpoint of the river Chambal and covers an area of 5,400 sq. km. It is a special ecological niche, being home to a variety of rare aquatic fauna such as the Ganges riverine dolphin, the red-crowned roof turtle and the